TEEN ENCOUNTER SYSTEM

Active: Day 2 (ambient) / Day 3 (full access) / Day 4 deadline **Location:** Abandoned barn, half mile east of Wroughtwood off the mill road **Package State:** Unopened — they don't know what it is yet

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THE FOUR TEENS

RICKY CALHOUN — 17, White

Aldous Calhoun's nephew. Runs on borrowed authority and knows it.

Ricky is loud in the way of someone who has never had to be quiet. He's grown up watching his uncle command rooms and has mistaken volume for power. He runs this group not because they respect him but because none of them have figured out they don't have to follow him yet. He found the car. The package was his idea to take. He's been holding it over the others ever since.

He takes an immediate dislike to Marcus — partially inherited from his uncle, partially because something in Marcus doesn't shrink the way Ricky expects things to shrink.

Approach — Rapport Path: Ricky can't be charmed directly. He has to be *outmaneuvered.* If Marcus builds rapport with the other three first, Ricky loses his grip on the group's opinion. He'll hand over the package rather than look isolated. His pride demands it.

Approach — Strength Path: Ricky folds fastest physically but creates the most blowback. He will absolutely tell his uncle. CALHOUN_PROVOKED escalates immediately.

Rapport Flag: RICKY_OUTMANEUVERED **Key Dialogue:** *"My uncle said you'd be trouble. Guess he was right."*

DELLA WASHINGTON — 16, Black

Sharecropper's daughter. Sharpest one in the barn and everyone knows it.

Della shouldn't be here. Not in Wroughtwood, not in this group, not within a mile of whatever Ricky took off that car. She's here because the alternative is home, and home is a conversation she stopped being able to have. She watches everything — people, situations, exits. When Marcus shows up she's the first one to stop looking at him like a threat and start looking at him like a question she wants answered.

She is the rapport path in. She recognizes something in Marcus she can't name — a person operating under pressure who hasn't broken yet. That means something to her.

She also has a quiet instinct about the package. She doesn't know what's in it but she knows it doesn't belong here.

Approach — Rapport Path: Talk to her honestly, even partially. She doesn't need the whole truth — she needs to believe Marcus isn't going to make things worse for people who already have it bad. She'll advocate for him to the group if she trusts him.

Approach — Strength Path: Della doesn't scare easily but she goes cold. She will remember. Later in the game she can become a minor ally — if Marcus used strength she won't be available for that.

Rapport Flag: DELLA_TRUSTS_MARCUS **Key Dialogue:** *"You're not from here. That means you know what it's like to be somewhere you're not supposed to be."*

TOMMY REED — 17, White

Preacher's kid. Reverend Cade's son. Already regretting every decision that led to this barn.

Tommy is the cautious one. He didn't want to take the package. He said so twice and got laughed at and took it anyway because seventeen and alone is a specific kind of desperate. He has been quietly panicking since the moment they opened the car door. He goes to church every Sunday and sits in the pew listening to his father not believe anymore and finds that more frightening than the package.

When Marcus shows up Tommy is three-quarters of the way to relieved. Someone came for it. Someone is going to take it away. He just needs permission to let it go.

Approach — Rapport Path: Easiest of the four. Tommy wants out. Give him a face-saving way to hand it over and he takes it immediately. If CADE_MET is set Marcus can mention the reverend obliquely — Tommy's expression does the rest.

Approach — Strength Path: Tommy breaks immediately and gives up everything — where the package is, who else knows, what Ricky said about Marcus. He is terrified and useful. But Marcus will feel it afterward. **HUMANITY -5** regardless of other strength path costs.

Rapport Flag: TOMMY_RELIEVED **Key Dialogue:** *"I told them we shouldn't have touched it. I said that. Nobody listened."*

HECTOR REYES — 18, Latino

Oldest one. Most volatile. Has the most to lose and acts like he has nothing.

Hector is eighteen and has been eighteen for a long time — the kind of eighteen that comes from watching the adult world be stupid and dangerous and deciding early that at least he could be dangerous too. His family works the mill. He has watched Calhoun look through his father for years. He is angry in a way that has gone structural, and he takes one look at Marcus — a Black man who came out of nowhere and is somehow still standing — and decides he either hates him or respects him and it could go either way fast.

He is the volatile one. He has a knife. He won't use it stupidly but he will use it.

Approach — Rapport Path: Hector responds to directness. Don't explain yourself, don't apologize, don't perform calm. Just be straight with him. If Marcus treats him like an equal — not a kid, not a problem — Hector comes around. He's been waiting his whole life to be treated like someone worth talking to.

Approach — Strength Path: Hector escalates. He pulls the knife. This triggers the **COMBAT TUTORIAL** — the first mechanical fight in the game. Winnable but not trivial. If Marcus uses lupine abilities here HECTOR_SAW_SOMETHING is set — Hector witnessed something he can't explain and it rewires how he thinks about Marcus entirely.

Rapport Flag: HECTOR_RESPECTS_MARCUS **Key Dialogue:** *"You think I'm scared of you? Man, I been scared of things that'd make you cry. You ain't even close."*

ENCOUNTER TIMELINE

DAY 2 — AMBIENT SIGNAL

Marcus can hear about the teens without seeking them out. Hattie mentions the barn obliquely during an inn job. A townsperson on the main road complains about *"those kids out by the old Pruitt barn."* Nothing actionable yet — just coordinates.

DAY 3 — FIRST CONTACT AVAILABLE

Marcus can go to the barn from Day 3 onward. The package is still unopened. The teens are present.

Arrival Scene: The barn sits off the mill road, listing slightly to one side like it gave up on being straight years ago. Inside — voices, the orange glow of a lantern, the smell of cigarettes somebody's mother doesn't know about.

They hear Marcus coming before he gets to the door. By the time he steps inside Ricky is standing, Hector is standing, Tommy has taken two steps back, and Della is watching from the corner with her arms crossed and an expression that is already three moves ahead of everyone else.

The package is on an old feed crate in the center of the barn. Unopened. A brick of brown paper wrapping and twine, unremarkable, the kind of thing that could be anything.

"The hell are you?" Ricky says.

PLAYER CHOICES — First Approach

A — Address the group as a whole *"That package belongs to me. I just want it back."*

- Clean. Direct. Gives Ricky nothing to grab onto.
- **COMPOSURE maintains.** The group reacts based on individual dispositions — Della uncrosses her arms slightly, Tommy exhales, Hector watches, Ricky inflates.

B — Address Della specifically *She's the one paying attention. Start there.*

- Skips Ricky's posturing entirely. Ricky hates this.
- **DELLA_FIRST_APPROACH set.** TRUST_DELLA +2. Ricky's hostility escalates faster but the group dynamic shifts.

C — Address Hector *Meet the volatile one head on before he decides.*

- High risk, high reward. Hector either respects it or escalates immediately.
- **RAGE CHECK:** If RAGE > 40 something in Marcus's tone is off and Hector catches it. Knife comes out faster.

D — Say nothing. Walk toward the package.

- **[HUMANITY CHECK]** If HUMANITY > 60 — Marcus moves with enough quiet authority that the room holds its breath. He gets three steps before Hector moves.
- If HUMANITY < 60 — something in how Marcus moves is wrong. Not human wrong. Ricky steps back without meaning to. CALHOUN_UNSETTLED upgrades.

RAPPORT PATH — Multi-Visit System

> *The rapport path does not resolve in one visit. Marcus builds trust across multiple interactions, Day 3 through Day 4.*

RAPPORT VISIT 1 — Establish

Marcus doesn't get the package today. He gets a conversation. Each teen has one thing they need from him:

Teen	What They Need	How Marcus Provides It
Ricky	To not be embarrassed in front of the group	Let him save face — don't push, don't win visibly
Della	To believe Marcus won't make things worse for people like her	Be honest about his situation, even partially
Tommy	Permission to let it go	Give him a reason that isn't about fear
Hector	To be treated like an equal	Talk straight, no performance

End of Visit 1: Marcus leaves without the package but with partial trust flags set. The teens talk after he goes. Della says something. It shifts the room.

RAPPORT VISIT 2 — The Exchange

Marcus returns. The dynamic has changed. Tommy has the package in his hands when Marcus arrives. Della is standing near the door. Hector is sitting — sitting, not standing. Even Ricky is quieter.

"We didn't open it," Della says. *"We thought about it. We didn't."*

She looks at Marcus directly.

"You going to tell us what's in it?"

Player Choices:

- **Tell them it's better they don't know** → Tommy hands it over immediately. Hector nods once. PACKAGE_SECURED set.
- **Tell them the truth — it's drugs, it belongs to a dangerous man** → Silence. Then Hector stands up. *"Then you better get it out of here before that man comes looking."* He picks it up and holds it out. PACKAGE_SECURED set. HECTOR_RESPECTS_MARCUS set.
- **Lie about what it is** → Della's expression closes. She knows. Tommy hands it over anyway but DELLA_TRUSTS_MARCUS is not set — she'll remember the lie.

PACKAGE_SECURED set — Rapport Path complete. Stat Effect: HUMANITY +10, TOWN_REP +10, TEENS_RAPPORT set

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STRENGTH PATH — Single Visit

> *Available at any point. Faster. Costs more.*

Marcus uses enhanced presence, physical intimidation, the thing behind his eyes that isn't entirely his anymore.

The room changes when he does it. The lantern light seems different. Ricky backs up first. Tommy makes a sound. Della goes still in the specific way of someone who is filing information away.

Hector pulls the knife.

COMBAT TUTORIAL — Hector's Knife

> *Triggered by Strength Path approach OR if Marcus goes to the barn after Day 4 deadline without prior rapport.*

Pre-Combat Narration: The knife catches the lantern light. It's a decent blade — hunting knife, well kept. Hector holds it the way someone holds a thing they know how to use.

"I said back up," Hector says. His voice is steady. He's not performing.

The others have pressed to the walls. This is between Marcus and Hector now.

COMBAT SYSTEM — Under The Hood

> *D20 dice roll system. All rolls happen in VBA, results displayed as narrative outcomes.*

CORE MECHANICS

Attack Roll: d20 + ATTACK MODIFIER vs opponent DEFENSE VALUE

- Hit: Roll damage die
- Miss: Opponent gets reaction

ATTACK MODIFIER = (HEALTH / 20) rounded down **DEFENSE VALUE** = base 10 + opponent modifier

COMBAT STATS — Marcus vs Hector

Stat	Marcus (Base)	Hector
HP	Current HEALTH	45
Attack Mod	HEALTH/20	+2
Defense	10	12
Damage Die	d6	d4 (knife — small space, limited swing)

LUPINE ABILITIES — Combat Options

> *These do NOT cost HUMANITY or RAGE. They are physical enhancements Marcus is learning to access. Using them in front of witnesses sets flags but does not drain core stats.*

Ability	Effect	Unlock Condition	Witness Flag
Heightened Reflexes	+4 to Defense for one round	Always available	None — invisible
Lupine Strength	Damage die upgrades d6 → d10 for one strike	Always available	HECTOR_SAW_SOMETHING if used
Predator's Gaze	Opponent must roll Morale check (d20 vs 14) or lose their next action	Available if RAGE > 20	HECTOR_SAW_SOMETHING set
Pack Sense	Reveals opponent's next action before it happens — automatic dodge	Unlocks after Marie introduction	None — invisible

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COMBAT RESOLUTION — Hector

Marcus wins: Hector is disarmed or yields. He looks at Marcus — breathing hard, knife on the floor or still in hand but lowered. Something in his face has rearranged.

"What are you?" he says. Not afraid. Genuinely asking.

IF HECTOR_SAW_SOMETHING: *"I've seen dogs go like that. Before they bite."* He picks up the knife slowly, sheathes it. *"You ain't just a man."* He holds the package out. *"Take it. And whatever's coming for you — don't bring it here."* HECTOR_RESPECTS_MARCUS set — despite the strength path, witnessing something real earns a different kind of respect.

Marcus loses (HEALTH drops below 20): Hector pins Marcus. Doesn't use the knife. *"You done?"* He lets Marcus up. The package stays. **Day 4 deadline still active** — Marcus has to return.

Stat Effect (Strength Path resolution):

- PACKAGE_SECURED set
- HUMANITY -10
- TOWN_REP -15
- TEENS_STRENGTH_PATH set — Della won't fully trust Marcus. Ricky tells his uncle something happened at the barn.

DAY 4 DEADLINE — PACKAGE LOST

> *If Marcus has not visited the barn by end of Day 4:*

PACKAGE_LOST set. TEENS_HAVE_PACKAGE set.

The teens opened it on Day 4 morning. They don't know what it is but they know it's not nothing. Ricky took a small amount. Tommy is sick with guilt. Della is trying to figure out how to undo this. Hector is quietly furious at Ricky.

Finding the package now requires asking around town:

Marcus has to gather information through ambient NPC interactions. Each lead costs time and social exposure:

Source	Information Given	Cost
Hattie (if asked carefully)	*"Heard some kids been out by the old barn acting strange."*	Nothing — she volunteers it if HATTIE_PROBED_EARLY
Mill foreman	Saw teens heading toward the barn two days ago	Costs one job — Marcus has to work for him first
Marie (if TRUST_MARIE > 0)	*"I saw something the night your car sat empty on the road. Come back tonight."*	Triggers Marie night visit
Reverend Cade (if CADE_MET)	Tommy confessed to him. Cade tells Marcus where the barn is without telling him why he knows.	CADE_KNOWS_ABOUT_PACKAGE set

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MARIE'S INFORMATION — Night Visit Trigger

> *If Marcus asks Marie about the package or the car:*

She is standing at the edge of the swamp path when he approaches in the daylight. She doesn't seem surprised to see him. She never does.

"I saw your car," she says. *"Night it happened. I see most things that move on this land after dark."*

She looks at him the way she looked at him from behind the willows — patient, reading, already two conclusions ahead.

"What I saw isn't a daylight conversation." She turns toward the swamp. *"Come back tonight. Come alone. Come hungry."*

The last word lands differently than it should.

"I'll know if you ate," she adds, without turning around.

MARIE_NIGHT_VISIT_TRIGGERED set

MARIE NIGHT VISIT — Combat Introduction

Time: Night cycle, after 10pm **Location:** Swamp path → Marie's home

The path to the swamp at night is different from the path in daylight. The willows are heavier. The ground softer. Sounds that don't belong to anything Marcus can name move through the reeds.

He finds her fire before he finds her house.

She is sitting beside it, completely still, watching him approach. Behind her, half-visible in the dark — her home. Old wood, hanging bundles of dried things, a porch that has sunk into the earth slightly and made peace with it.

"Sit down, Marcus Grave," she says.

He sits.

She studies him across the fire for a long moment. Then — without ceremony — she throws something into the flames. The fire goes green. Just for a second. Then back to orange.

"I know what bit you," she says. *"I know what it wants. And I know you've been trying to hold it with both hands and it's been getting heavier every day."*

She reaches beside her and sets something on the ground between them. A clay bowl. Dark liquid.

"Before we talk — you need to learn what you are."

THE TEST

Something moves in the dark at the swamp's edge. Large. Low. Not subtle about itself.

Marie doesn't move. Doesn't look.

"That's been following you since the field," she says. *"Part of the pack. They send them to watch the new ones."*

She looks at Marcus now.

"Handle it."

COMBAT 2 — PACK SCOUT

> *First real combat encounter. Harder than Hector. Introduces full combat UI.*

Enemy: Pack Scout — infected animal, wolf-adjacent, fast and low **HP:** 60 **Attack Mod:** +4 **Defense:** 14 **Damage Die:** d8

Marcus's full combat options now visible for the first time:

Action	Type	Effect
Strike	Physical	d6 + Attack Mod
Lupine Strength	Ability	d10 + Attack Mod, one round
Heightened Reflexes	Ability	Defense +4, one round
Predator's Gaze	Ability	Morale check or enemy loses action
Dodge	Physical	No damage — enemy rerolls attack
Pack Sense*	Ability	Auto-dodge + counter d6

Pack Sense unlocks mid-combat — Marie speaks from behind Marcus during the fight: "Stop thinking like a man. Listen." **Pack Sense added to action bar permanently.**

Combat Resolution: Marcus wins. The scout retreats into the swamp. He is breathing hard — not from exertion. From something else. Something that felt like recognition.

Marie is watching him from the fire.

"Good," she says. *"Now we talk."*

MARIE_FORMALLY_MET set COMBAT_SYSTEM_UNLOCKED set PACK_SENSE_UNLOCKED set Stat Effect: HUNGER +15 — combat feeds it. RAGE -10 — using the wolf *correctly* quiets it.

FLAGS SET / MODIFIED

Flag	Condition
TEENS_FIRST_CONTACT	Any barn visit
DELLA_TRUSTS_MARCUS	Rapport path, honest with Della
TOMMY_RELIEVED	Rapport path, Tommy releases package
HECTOR_RESPECTS_MARCUS	Rapport path OR strength path with HECTOR_SAW_SOMETHING
RICKY_OUTMANEUVERED	Rapport path complete
PACKAGE_SECURED	Either path, package recovered
PACKAGE_LOST	Day 4 passes without barn visit
TEENS_HAVE_PACKAGE	Day 4 deadline missed
TEENS_RAPPORT	Full rapport path complete
TEENS_STRENGTH_PATH	Strength path used
HECTOR_SAW_SOMETHING	Lupine ability used in combat
MARIE_NIGHT_VISIT_TRIGGERED	Marie asked about car/package
MARIE_FORMALLY_MET	Night visit completed
COMBAT_SYSTEM_UNLOCKED	Night visit combat won
PACK_SENSE_UNLOCKED	Night visit combat won